

Word family: **neat** / neater / neatest / neatly / neatness

Base word: neat

Comparative: neater

Superlative: neatest

Part of speech: mainly **adjective**

Related forms:

* **neat** (adj.) — 整齊的；整潔的；俐落的；巧妙的

* **neatly** (adv.) — 整齊地；俐落地；巧妙地

* **neatness** (n.) — 整齊；整潔；俐落

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **neat appearance**

* **neat clothes**

* **neat handwriting**

* **neat room**

* **neat pile**

* **neat solution**

* **neat idea**

* **neat trick**

* **neat fit**

* **neat and tidy**

* **neatly arranged**

* **neatly dressed**

Meaning in this passage

> He was quite tall and thin, and he always looked **neat** and well-organised.

Here, **neat** means:

clean, tidy, and carefully arranged in appearance — 整潔的；整齊的；俐落的

The speaker is describing Mr Chan's **personal appearance**.

He looked tidy, presentable, and carefully put together.

中文翻譯：

他身形頗高也偏瘦，而且總是看起來很**整潔、俐落**，也很有條理。

So here:

look neat = 看起來整潔、衣着和外表整理得很好

1. **neat (人的外表：整潔的) — 整潔的；俐落的**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He always looked **neat** and well-organised.

他看起來總是很**整潔俐落**，也很有條理。

Practice 2

> She looked **neat and professional** in her uniform.

她穿着制服，看起來**整潔又專業**。

Practice 3

> He keeps his appearance simple but **neat**.

他的外表雖然簡單，但很**整潔**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****neat = 外表乾淨、整齊、沒有凌亂感的****

2. **neat clothes / appearance — 整齊衣着 / 外表**

Practice 1

> He wore **neat clothes** to the interview.

他穿着**整齊的衣服**去面試。

Practice 2

> Her **neat appearance** made a good first impression.

她**整潔的外表**留下了良好的第一印象。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****neat clothes/appearance = 整理得乾淨、得體、不凌亂的衣着或外表****

3. ****neat room / desk — 整齊的房間 / 桌面****

Practice 1

> His desk is always ****neat****.

他的書桌總是很****整齊****。

Practice 2

> She keeps her room ****neat and tidy****.

她一直把房間保持得****整齊乾淨****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****neat = 物件排列整齊、沒有雜亂的****

4. ****neat handwriting — 工整的字跡****

Practice 1

> She has very ****neat handwriting****.

她的字寫得非常****工整****。

Practice 2

> Please write your answers in ****neat handwriting****.

請用****工整的字跡****寫答案。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****neat handwriting = 字形清楚、排列整齊、容易閱讀的筆跡****

5. ****neat arrangement / pile — 整齊的排列 / 一疊****

Practice 1

> The books were stacked in a **neat pile**.

那些書**整整齊齊地**疊成一堆。

Practice 2

> The chairs were arranged in **neat rows**.

椅子被**整齊地**排成幾行。

MCQ-ready definition:

neat arrangement = 物件以有秩序、整齊的方式排列

6. **neatly** — 整齊地；俐落地

Practice 1

> The papers were **neatly arranged** on the desk.

文件在桌上**整齊地**排列着。

Practice 2

> He was **neatly dressed** in a plain shirt and dark trousers.

他穿着簡單恤衫和深色長褲，打扮得很**整潔俐落**。

MCQ-ready definition:

neatly = 以整齊、整潔、有秩序的方式

7. **neat** (做工俐落 / 精準的) — 俐落的；精巧的

A useful extension from visual tidiness to precise execution.

Practice 1

> She made a **neat cut** with the knife.

她用刀切出了一個很**俐落整齊的**切口。

Practice 2

> The carpenter did a **neat job** on the shelves.

木匠把架子做得很**俐落精細**。

MCQ-ready definition:

neat = 做得準確、乾淨、沒有多餘或凌亂部分的

8. **neat solution — 巧妙簡潔的解決方法**

This is an important abstract sense.

Practice 1

> That's a **neat solution** to the problem.

那是一個**巧妙而簡潔的解決方法**。

Practice 2

> The engineer came up with a **neat way** to reduce waste.

那位工程師想出了一個**巧妙俐落的方法**來減少浪費。

MCQ-ready definition:

neat solution = 簡潔、巧妙而有效，不需要複雜方法的解決方案

9. **neat idea — 不錯 / 巧妙的想法**

Practice 1

> That's a **neat idea**.

那是一個很**不錯 / 巧妙的想法**。

Practice 2

> She had a **neat idea** for organising the files.

她想到一個**很巧妙的方法**整理文件。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****neat idea = 簡單、聰明、令人欣賞的想法****

10. ****neat trick — 巧妙的小技巧****

Practice 1

> Let me show you a ****neat trick****.

讓我給你看看一個****很巧妙的小技巧****。

Practice 2

> That's a ****neat trick**** for remembering names.

那是一個記名字的****巧妙方法****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****neat trick = 聰明、簡單而有效的小方法或技巧****

11. ****neat (informal AmE : 很酷 / 很不錯) — 很棒的 ; 很酷的****

This informal sense is especially associated with American English and can sound a little old-fashioned depending on speaker/context.

Practice 1

> That's really ****neat****!

那真的很****酷 / 很棒****！

Practice 2

> Your new camera is pretty ****neat****.

你的新相機挺****不錯的****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****neat = informal: 很好、很吸引、很令人欣賞的****

12. ****neat** (飲品：純飲、不加冰或其他東西) — 純飲的******

A genuinely distinct drinks-related sense.

Practice 1

> He ordered the whisky ****neat****.

他點了****純飲威士忌****，不加冰也不加水。

Practice 2

> She prefers brandy ****neat****.

她喜歡****純飲白蘭地****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****neat = 酒類不加水、冰塊、汽水或其他飲料直接飲用的****

13. ****neat** (液體 / 化學品：未稀釋的) — 純的；未稀釋的******

A more technical extension of the drinks sense.

Practice 1

> Do not use the chemical ****neat**** on your skin.

不要把這種化學品****未經稀釋直接使用****在皮膚上。

Practice 2

> The solution should not be applied ****neat****.

這種溶液不應****以原液形式直接使用****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****neat = 未經稀釋、混合或添加其他物質的****

14. ****neat fit** — 剛好合適；貼合整齊******

Practice 1

> The box is a **neat fit** in the cupboard.

這個盒子放進櫃子裏**大小剛剛好**。

Practice 2

> The parts form a **neat fit**.

這些零件組合起來**非常貼合**。

MCQ-ready definition:

neat fit = 尺寸剛好、貼合得整齊而沒有多餘空間

15. **neat and tidy — 整齊乾淨**

Very common fixed pairing.

Practice 1

> Keep your desk **neat and tidy**.

把你的書桌保持得**整齊乾淨**。

Practice 2

> The classroom was always **neat and tidy**.

課室總是**乾乾淨淨、整整齊齊**。

MCQ-ready definition:

neat and tidy = 乾淨、有秩序、沒有凌亂的

16. **neatness — 整齊；整潔；工整**

Practice 1

> The teacher praised the **neatness** of her work.

老師稱讚她作業的**整潔工整**。

Practice 2

> He is known for the **neatness** of his desk.

他以書桌十分**整齊**而聞名。

MCQ-ready definition:

neatness = 整齊、乾淨、有秩序的特質

Important distinction 1: **neat vs tidy**

Very close, but there is a useful nuance.

tidy

focuses strongly on things being put in the correct place and not messy.

neat

can mean tidy, but also:

- * visually orderly
- * precise
- * compact
- * well executed

> a tidy room

整潔房間

> neat handwriting

工整字跡

You would not usually say **tidy handwriting**.

Important distinction 2: **neat vs clean**

clean

free from dirt.

neat

orderly and visually tidy.

A desk can be:

- * clean but messy

- * neat but dusty

So:

neat ≠ clean

although they often occur together.

Important distinction 3: **neat vs well-organised**

This is especially relevant to your passage.

neat

describes visible orderliness.

well-organised

describes effective arrangement, planning, and management.

So:

> He looked **neat and well-organised**.

means roughly:

- * appearance → neat

- * manner/system/personality → well-organised

The two words complement each other rather than simply repeat the same idea.

Important distinction 4: **neat vs smart**

In British English:

smart

can mean stylish, well-dressed, or formal-looking.

neat

means orderly, clean, and tidy-looking.

> a smart suit

一套醒目 / 得體的西裝

> a neat shirt

一件整潔俐落的恤衫

Important distinction 5: **neat vs elegant**

neat

orderly, clean, simple, precise.

elegant

graceful, stylish, sophisticated.

A solution can be both:

> a neat and elegant solution

一個簡潔又漂亮的解決方案

But **elegant** usually carries stronger aesthetic or intellectual admiration.

Important distinction 6: **neat solution vs simple solution**

simple solution

not complicated.

neat solution

usually suggests:

- * simple
- * clever
- * efficient
- * satisfying

So **neat** adds a sense of ingenuity.

Important distinction 7: **neat idea vs good idea**

good idea

broadly positive.

neat idea

often suggests cleverness, simplicity, or originality.

So:

> neat idea

can feel more like:

幾巧妙㗎 / 幾醒目嘅諗法

in conversational Hong Kong-style interpretation.

Important distinction 8: **neat handwriting vs clear handwriting**

neat handwriting

visually orderly and carefully formed.

clear handwriting

easy to read.

Usually neat handwriting is clear, but theoretically handwriting could be clear without looking especially neat.

Important distinction 9: **neat appearance vs formal appearance**

neat

tidy/presentable.

formal

appropriate for official or serious settings.

Someone can look neat in casual clothes.

So Mr Chan's **plain shirt and dark trousers** can look neat without being highly formal.

Important distinction 10: **neat vs orderly**

orderly

organized according to a system or sequence.

neat

visually tidy and precise.

> an orderly process

有秩序的過程

> a neat desk

整齊桌面

Important distinction 11: **neat = tidy vs neat = clever**

These are distinct learner senses.

Physical

> a **neat room**

整齊的房間

Abstract

> a **neat solution**

巧妙簡潔的解決方法

The second sense metaphorically extends the idea of something being **cleanly arranged with no unnecessary mess**.

Important distinction 12: **neat = tidy** vs **neat = undiluted**

These are completely different modern uses.

> a **neat shirt**

整潔的恤衫

> whisky **neat**

純飲威士忌

Context makes the meaning clear.

Important distinction 13: **neatly** vs **cleanly**

neatly

in an orderly/precise way.

cleanly

without dirt, or with a smooth complete action.

> neatly arranged books

整齊排列的書

> cut cleanly through the rope

乾脆利落地切斷繩子

They overlap in some action contexts but are not interchangeable generally.

Family-extension note

****Neat**** has several useful modern branches built around the idea of:

**order, precision, and absence of mess**

The major senses are:

1. ****physical tidiness****

- * neat person
- * neat clothes
- * neat room

2. ****visual precision****

- * neat handwriting
- * neat rows
- * neat cut

3. ****abstract cleverness****

- * neat solution
- * neat idea
- * neat trick

4. ****informal approval****

- * That's neat!

5. ****undiluted****

- * whisky neat
- * use the chemical neat

So this is a good example of a word where a seemingly simple adjective has developed several genuinely useful modern meanings.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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neat person/appearance	整潔的 ; 俐落的	tidy appearance	
neat clothes	整齊衣着	presentable	
neat room/desk	整齊房間 / 桌面	orderly	
neat handwriting	工整字跡	visually precise	
neat pile/rows	整齊排列	orderly arrangement	
neatly dressed	穿著整潔	tidy manner	
neat cut/job	俐落精準的切口 / 工作	precise execution	
neat solution	巧妙簡潔的解決方法	clever + simple	
neat idea	巧妙想法	clever idea	
neat trick	巧妙技巧	clever method	
neat!	很酷 / 很不錯	informal approval	
whisky neat	純飲威士忌	undiluted	
use it neat	原液直接使用	not diluted	
neat fit	剛好貼合	precise fit	
neat and tidy	整齊乾淨	orderly/clean	
neatness	整齊 ; 整潔	quality of orderliness	

For your original sentence

> He was quite tall and thin, and he always looked **neat** and well-organised.

Here:

neat = 外表整潔、衣着俐落、不凌亂

The word is mainly describing his **visible appearance**, while **well-organised** extends the description toward his orderly manner and way of managing things.

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 他身形頗高也偏瘦，而且總是看起來很**整潔俐落、很有條理**。

For this context, **「整潔俐落」** captures **neat** particularly well.